

WTC Snow Camp 2009

North Lake area above Bishop

This past weekend was the final and most anticipated / dreaded of the WTC outings: Snow Camp! Spend three days and two nights freezing your rear end off up in the Sierras! Find joy in waking up to your boots frozen solid along with any and all liquid you had outside of your sleeping bag! Much fun!

Last year when Kim and I were students I had been disappointed by the lack of a blizzard during snow camp. The depressingly sunny and warm weather had allowed us to do quite a bit while we were up there but I had really wanted to have to dig our way out of our tent in the morning.

This year I had once again talked long and loud about my hopes for a blizzard and once again the weather didn't behave. But on the plus side this year we had more snow and it got much colder.

Friday we met mid-morning and with varying amounts of enthusiasm piled into the bus for the long ride to Bishop.



The on-bus movie was Wayne's World in honor of Group 2's (our group's) theme.



Along the way we almost starved. I think there was a 40 minute period in there somewhere where someone wasn't trying to feed me something.

It was afternoon by the time we pulled into Bishop across the street from the ever famous Shatz bakery. Kim promptly became a projectile and shoved leaders and students alike aside in order to be at the front of the bakery sandwich line.

Strangely enough this picture happened before she shoved her way off the bus...



Then she rode the horsey...



The sandwich was to be the last non-backpacking food we would see for the next two or three days so we enjoyed it as much as possible before wandering back over to a local park where we changed into our warm gear and piled back into the bus to drive up the mountain.

At this point the two Orange County WTC groups split up. Group 1 was dropped off at South Lake while we were dropped off at the end of the North Lake fork. The road is only plowed so far, once the bus reaches that point we pile out and start walking.



After minimal confusion we were dressed and had our snow shoes strapped on and began the trek up to Sabrina Campground. We still had some light as we started up the road but that faded before we made it to camp.



Sadly, there was not a cloud in the sky. So much for my blizzard. Maybe next year!

The moon was extremely bright and as we hiked if you turned off your headlamp it was almost like there was a streetlight above you illuminating the snow.

Based on our progress to that point we decided to stay the night at the Sabina Campground and move the next day to our ultimate goal at the back of North Lake. I would have just as soon hiked all the way in that night (as several of my various trip participants will attest) but apparently there was some concern about students stepping off the road and plummeting to a grisly death. Eh.

Setting up camp consisted of stomping out flat platforms in the snow so we could pitch our tents. For those who wanted to be fancy they could dig out a pit at each entrance to the tent allowing gear storage under the fly and a convenient place to put on or take off boots.



Once the tent set up the main activity becomes how to stay warm. Since we're on snow if you stand still the cold will slowly leech through the bottom of your boots and you can't sit anywhere without putting down some sort of insulation. Also since you've presumably been sweating as you hike in you need to

immediately change clothes once you get into camp which means briefly stripping off those warm layers. Ah snow camping.

So situated one then looks to hot liquid and food. Stoves are broken out and you discover if the stove which worked so well at home in your kitchen will function in two degree weather while sitting on ice.



After helping Kim set up the three season (e.g., not intended for use in the dead of winter like we were doing) I started on a personal project, building a snow shelter.



Unfortunately this was going to be a learning experience as far as shelter construction goes. The fact the temperature was in the single digits and dropping fast meant the snow blocks I was using to construct the shelter wouldn't melt together. After attempting unsuccessfully to span the roof with snow blocks I admitted defeat and used an emergency blanket and snow poles spanned by snowshoes.



The large entrance made it unusable in its current form as a shelter so while it provided some entertainment to the students I ended up spending the night with Kim in the tent. But hey, at least it kept me warm and entertained building it.

In addition to hot food and water we did our best to keep the students moving. This included...

...forming a conga line...



...and doing the Macarena...



..all the while watching the temperature approach zero. Our best guess is that the temperature reached at least zero that night.

It was a late night by the standards of most of the trips I've been on when the main group broke up and headed for our tents.

There was one minor occurrence when Chris, one of the students, approached with a little toe that was mostly white. I jumped into action and promptly took a picture much to the student's consternation.



After a short discussion it was decided that I wouldn't amputate the toe with my Leatherman and that it had just been bunched against the side of very tight boots. Ah well, amputation pictures next year maybe.



Crisis averted Kim and I bundled up and climbed into our somewhat drafty tent for the night.

The next morning it was a balmy 6 degrees and our camp took its time packing up and moving out. This is opposed to last year when we were woken up at the crack of dawn with Ron Campbell loudly counting down the number of minutes until we were to have our packs and be ready to go. Instead our somewhat more sedate leadership had us out of camp sometime after 10 as we shouldered our packs and strolled up the road towards North Lake.

Again, part of the reason we hadn't continued on to North Lake the night before is the road has a fairly steep drop to one side. I had never actually been up to North Lake because whenever Dad and I have fished the area in October / November the road is icy and dangerous to drive. Now I can understand why everyone warns us away.



The other reason would be that no one besides me seems to enjoy hiking through pitch black wilderness with nothing illuminated save the small circle made by ones headlamp.

As happened last year we had once against drafted Virgil Talbot, boyfriend extraordinaire of one of the other leaders and all around highly knowledgeable mountain man, into coming out to help us. This year instead of camping in a tent Virgil and Gwen came up early and constructed an igloo to stay in.



Gwen looks less than thrilled off to the side because the part of the igloo Virgil is resting on has her gear underneath.

Inside it was quite comfortable



Virgil was kind enough to give a quick talk about cutting snow blocks and general snow construction before we continued on to our destinations, the North Lake campground.

We had a quiet and somber hike into camp...



And then once we got there for some reason this happed:



Don't ask. I don't know. My camera was taken from me and pictures were taken.

Meanwhile Kim and I were off in a snow bank digging out snow shelters. After the previous nights failure I was determined to spend the second night sleeping in a nice warm shelter. With the sun still up the loose snow was allowing me to join blocks successfully making things infinitely more productive.

What followed was a loooong couple of hours digging, cutting blocks, hauling blocks, and shoveling snow. The original plan called for two one person shelters linked at the bottom, one for Kim and one for me. That ended up changing as it got later and the temperature again dropped with Kim's still not finished.

Instead we took the one person shelter I had built and with late assistance by Virgil and Gwen expanded it into a two person dwelling.



For all the work and sweat that went into building it I do have to say it was one of the nicest nights I've spent out in the snow. With two people sleeping in the shelter the air warmed up quickly and Kim and I were stripping off layers the moment we were inside. Kim, who basically gets cold even when we camp in the summer managed to stay warm all night.

But before climbing into the shelter we joined the group at the snow table (which had been constructed by the students while Kim and I were off digging.)



As usual there was so much food being passed around there was little point in cooking the dinner we had brought.

After working on the shelter for hours I had been soaked in sweat. When we stopped I changed completely in to dry clothes but it still took me quite a while to warm up. For the first hour or so at the snow table I just huddled up in my down jacket and ate whatever someone put in front of me.

After the food was done we ended up playing a game where everyone tells one truth and one lie and you vote on which is which. I was dragged into it just before we left the table. Mine were:

1. I've been involved in two helicopter rescues
2. I've been directly responsible for one helicopter rescue

My reputation being what it is all the students voted #2. Ha! Not true!

Leaving the last few folks at the table Kim and I climbed into our shelter and quickly shed layers before climbing into our bags.

The next morning I made breakfast in the shelter which was a nice change from stomping around out in the wind waiting for water to boil.



Sadly it was now Sunday which meant we were leaving and our beautifully constructed shelter would have to come down. Leave no trace.

But first, we tested how strong the construction was. As you can see it supported both Kim and I with no hint of give.



Go little snow shelter! Sadly it was noticeably less resistant to strategic use of a snow saw and boot.

After breaking camp we set a leisurely pace back down to Gwen and Virgil's' igloo.

Here we walked up a nearby hillside and did some basic instruction on snowshoeing,



Why you don't walk on a cornice:



And in the newly minted tradition of our group, a heavily unbalanced snow balls fight.



And finally it's not a trip with Matt unless we get a group shot.



The scenery on the way down was quite pleasant. There was noticeably more snow meltage, especially on the road, but we still were able to use our snowshoes.





From there it was all downhill to get to the bus with a single stop for one last brutal snowball fight. No pictures were taken due to the fact I couldn't go 20 seconds without getting hit by a snowball. Good times!



After a triumphant march back to the bus it was time to rejoin civilization. No more going days without bathing or peeing wherever the urge came upon you.

The traditional first stop once we were back in town is Pizza Factory. Beer + greasy pizza, what more could one ask for?



After chowing down on greasy pizza we were back on the bus for the long ride home.

Whoever picked the movies this year is officially fired. Next year I'm going to make them all watch *Alive* or something equally horrifying.

Last year we had:



This year we had:



Granted, I think more people made it to work the following day this year as opposed to last but still, the bus ride home was a sad shadow of the previous year.

And with that WTC was over, at least until October when those students who have completed at least two experience trips will rejoin us in Joshua Tree for graduation and the ultimate reward, the WTC patch!